Chapter 16: Give a Gift. Get Shot.

"We should get married soon," Erik suggested as he and Catria sat on a bench outside of Cruia's headquarters looking at the stars.

"It's only a few weeks," Catria pointed out. "The time will fly. I am so excited. My mother is planning such a large celebration."

"In Cruia, we don't care about fancy," Erik explained. "People get married, and everyone brings food, someone plays a fiddle, and everyone dances."

Catria's smile glowed as she complimented, "You are a good dancer."

Erik shrugged. "Everyone in Cruia dances. It's an inexpensive pastime, and so much fun. We just aren't proper and haughty like the dances in Aschelle."

"I love Cruia," Catria assured him. "I'd be happy to live here, but I'm glad we'll be living in Terrian."

"It's a great city," Erik assured her. "For now, I'm

going to keep living in Terrian and fighting with Cruia, but we'll work things out so we are on the same team."

"And we'll visit here often," Catria assured him. "Your family is great."

"They are," Erik agreed. "In fact, my sister made this for me to give to you." He pulled out a necklace made of pewter and handed it to her. It had a rose quarts heart set in it, and a pewter rose.

Catria gasped. "It's beautiful!"

Erik smiled back. "So are you."

Catria blushed. "Mqybe we should move the wedding up."

Erik didn't say anything back, but held his hand up for her to be quiet.

She knew what that meant – trouble!

A scream rang through the air, and Erik ran the direction it came from. Catria followed.

Henry and Xena were fighting several phyrnians.

Erik and Catria charged in to help with the fight.

Blood being drawn outside the arena by a war mage would mean his death, so Erick didn't use his whip. There wasn't any need to. The men after Xena weren't war mages.

Henry didn't use his blades either. Both men just used their fists.

"Stay back," Eric called to Catria. "You too Xena. We

have this."

He was right that he and Henry made quick work of knocking out all eight of the attacking men.

Once they had them tied tied and brought to the sheriff, Erik asked. "What happened?"

Henry explained, "I was on watch and suddenly heard screaming and saw Xena running this way being pursued by Phyrnians. Apparently, they aren't giving up on getting her back."

"there will be a big price on my head," Xena pointed out.

Henry suddenly turned to her and asked, "What were you doing alone? Aren't you staying with the Brannings? They have four strong sons to protect you."

"A Faeborn charmed them," Xena explained. "We were eating at The Silver Spur. Apparently, the Phyrnians had a faeborn grimilkin or grogosh who put fairy wine in their drinks. When the Phyrnian men came after me, the Branning brothers started reciting rhymes to tell them to stop, but didn't fight."

Henry shook his head. "That can be a side effect to fairy wine. It always does something odd." He signed. "Xena, I think you need to be protected by a war mage. I volunteer. I'll talk to Dillion about it."

"Didn't he think I'd be too easy to find that way?" Xena asked.

"You were found anyway," Henry pointed out.

“Dillion will be fine with it. I’m now your protector if that’s all right with you.”

Xena smiled, but then her smile fell flat. “What’s it mean to you to be my protector? Will you own me?”

“Own?” Henry asked with some shock. “In Cruia, we don’t own people. We own animals.”

The smile came back to Xena’s face. “Then I accept. Thank you. What do you want me to do?”

“I have chores I wouldn’t mind you helping with, but I think we ought to consider having you forge your war mage weapon.”

“I don’t want to be a war mage,” Xena argued.

“You won’t need to be,” Henry assured her. “Here in Cruia, we don’t have female war mages. We believe men should protect women. I think you may want to forge your weapon to better protect yourself. You do have war mages after you.”

She raised an eyebrow. “Are you not afraid I will fight you?”

Henry chuckled. “I’m a man and an experienced war mage. I am not afraid of you. In fact, I’d like to know what you do want to do with your life? I have to work the farm and practice as a war mage, but my family does leather working, and my mom and sisters are great cooks. Are you interested in learning to sew or do you already know how?”

“I am interested in learning to do everything the way

people outside of Phyrn do. I really want to give that life up and learn to be a good Cruian woman."

"Then this should be an exciting project," Henry noted. "Do you like to dance?"

"Not Phyrnian dances," she answered. "But I would love to learn to dance like you do here."

"Then this could be fun," Henry suggested. "Now, let's go. We need to talk to Dillion and check on the Branning boys. Besides, we interrupted Erik and Catria."

He took her hand and pulled her off.

"Do we need to help them?" Catria asked. "I'm worried about all the people trying to get Xena back for Phyrn."

"I am too," Erik admitted. "Especially since faeborn seem to be involved. Some of them have incredible powers, and their war mages' familiars could be watching us without us knowing."

"Why would they be watching us?" Catria asked. "Seriously, I'm just a healer, not a threat."

"Oh no," Erik corrected, "you are a threat to them, so am…"

An arrow suddenly whizzed through the air, straight at Erik. He didn't worry as he had shielding, but instinctively put up an energy shield. Still, the arrow got through and hit him in the gut, fortunately not in the chest. How? No weapon should be able to get through a war mages shielding.

Erik didn’t worry about how, as he was more concerned about bleeding to death. He screamed in pain as he fell to the ground with blood gushing from the wound.

Catria was instantly by him, healing him. With her help, he’d live, but the attacker would get away. Even worse, he might strike again.

Another arrow didn’t come because Henry and Xena came riding up.

Henry pulled his knives as he looked around for the attacker.

After searching a few moments, he announced, “It looks like he ran away.”

“Quiet,” Catria urged. “I need to heal him.”

She worked a few moments before announcing, “He’ll heal, but this was bad.”

“I know,” Erik mumbled. “Even worse. It never should have happened. Somehow the arrow got through war mage shielding like it wasn’t there. That terrifies me.”